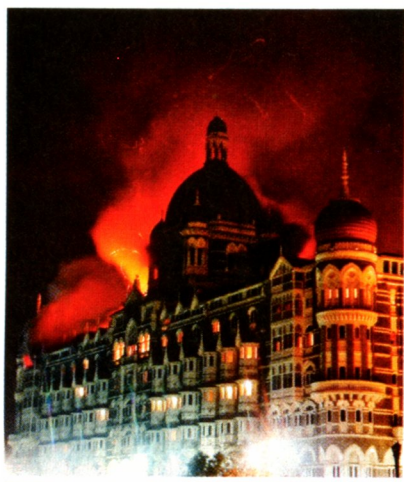




Slow and UNSTEADY

Mumbai continues to live in fear as terror alerts pour in every day. While the state is working on a blueprint, the police force remains ill-equipped to handle a major attack.

By Malini Bhupta and Swati Mathur

Mumbai is on the edge. Eight months after the gruesome 26/11 terror attacks shook the city, India's financial capital is on its toes as each day brings with it a new threat. India's urbs prima is on red alert at all times. An e-mail threatens to blow up a suburban station one day and on another intelligence reports warn of an attack on a vital installation. Snipers at high-profile locations, checkpoints across the city and gun-toting officers outside malls and hospitals are a common sight. At one level, the sight of policemen armed with carbines reflects the state's preparedness, but reality reveals otherwise.

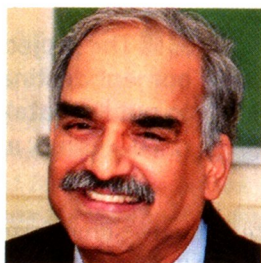
Mumbai is yet to get its own crack force, which can combat and restrict any terror attack, because change has been slow both in the corridors of power and within the police force. The over 352-member commando unit of the state, Force One, which was to be ready by March 2009, is still not operational. In these eight months, not a single bulletproof jacket (BPJ) or helmet has been bought. Explains a senior police officer, "Post-26/11, only heads of politicians rolled but an enlightened leadership was still missing in the police force."

But the tables have turned ever since former Mumbai police commissioner Hasan Gafoor moved out, claim

police officials. With the appointment of D. Sivanandhan as the new commissioner and Chandra Iyengar as home secretary, a lot of dynamism has come into the force. Iyengar is burning the midnight oil with DGP S.S. Virk and Sivanandhan to set the house in order as swiftly as possible. Their plan to fortify the state, Mumbai in particular, is ambitious, bordering on the audacious. From creating and training assault mobile teams to uniting multiple surveillance systems across the city on a single platform, a complete overhaul is due for the force. Says Sivanandhan:

"I have to ensure we are prepared for any eventuality." And for that he isn't wasting any time. If his boys need BPJs, he makes sure that they get them, despite bureaucratic fetters. It's another matter that the first 100 BPJs arrived eight months after 26/11 and they too are samples for which the government has not had to pay.

After taking over, the first thing the city police chief has done is to deploy mobile assault vehicles. Over time, all the 39 Assistant Commissioner of Police Divisions will be armed with at least one assault vehicle and a team of



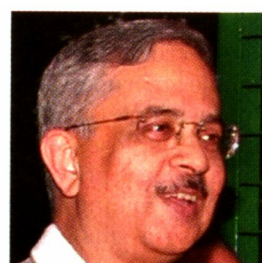
DHANUSHYAKODI SIVANANDHAN, Mumbai Police Commissioner 58

Served as state intelligence chief. His kind of decisive leadership is required at this point to unite a disjointed and ineffective police force.



S. JAGANNATHAN, DIG and Head of Force One 47

As chief of the crack commando team, he is currently training 256 cadets. The team will be the first to respond within 10 minutes of a crisis.



JAYANT UMRANIKAR, DG (Special Operations) 58

Will handle urban terror and insurgency after being promoted as DG (Special Operations). The Government has defined his role after three months of confusion.